MAHARASHTRA

PUSH FOR WILD BUFFALOES

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BUFFALO CALL

- **Maharashtra is starting a captive breeding programme of wild water buffaloes brought from Kolamarka forest in Gadchiroli and Assam**
- **It will help conservation, re-introduction in the wild to bolster falling numbers**
- **Most Indian wild water buffaloes are found in Assam. Only around 60 survive in Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra**

In a country where the cow is the venerated bovine, Maharashtra seems to be sparing a thought for its buffaloes. At least the wild water (*Bubalus arnee*) variety. India may have 91 per cent of the world's wild water buffalo population of around 3,400, but it is listed as 'Endangered' on the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) Red List and under Schedule 1 of the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972, giving it a conservation status at par with animals like tigers and elephants. A majority of Indian wild buffaloes are concentrated in the Northeast, particularly in Assam. A creature of wet grasslands, swamps and densely vegetated river valleys, a small population—an estimated 60—survives in central India, dispersed in the Kolamarka-Kopela forests of Maharashtra, and in the Indravati and Udanti-Sitanadi tiger reserves in Chhattisgarh. With wild water buffaloes considered crucial to maintain the food chain and ecological balance of their natural habitat, the Maharashtra State Board for Wildlife (MSBWL) has given its nod for its captive breeding.

The MSBWL, which met under Chief Minister Eknath Shinde in September, says the programme will complement the conservation of the animal and will involve a reintroduction of animal in the wild. "The wild buffalo population has declined and hence this attempt to increase its numbers," Sudhir Mungantiwar, minister, forests, tells INDIA TODAY.

The Maharashtra government had declared a 180.72 sq. km area in Kolamarka in Gadchiroli district as a conservation reserve in 2013 to protect the buffaloes. In 2022, it was upgraded to a wildlife sanctuary. A 2017 estimation put the zone's population at 22; a forest department officer says the herd at Kolamarka numbers between 25 and 50. "Numbers vary and overlap as these animals move across the two states...depending on the water level in the Indravati river. But there seem to be two groups in Chhattisgarh and one in Maharashtra," the official explains. "Wild buffaloes are the source of the dairy industry as domestic buffaloes descended from them. So, it is necessary to protect the wild population," says Kishor Rithe, director, Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS), and member, MSBWL. BNHS is preparing the proposal for the captive breeding and reintroduction of wild buffaloes in areas in central India.

"The breeding project will see wild buffaloes from Kolamarka and Assam being brought to the Gorewada zoo at Nagpur in stages.... Once successful, the breeding stock will be kept at Gorewada and surplus animals will be released in the wild—in Pench, Tadoba Andhari and Navegaon-Nagzira tiger reserves," says Rithe. In an article for the BNHS magazine *Hornbill*, Rithe wrote that it is crucial to have a captive-bred population of genetically pure wild water buffaloes in central India for restocking wild populations. "The success of this programme would not only aid in their recovery, but also contribute to the restoration of grasslands and swamp habitats," he wrote. ■